captaining the national team, even though I was making mistakes and still learning ... almost every aspect, except addressing the media, especially addressing the media after we had once again been eliminated from an ICC limited-overs tournament.

The C-word was coming, so I addressed the issue before the question was even asked.

'In the big moments, the pressure moments when it mattered, we were found wanting,' I told the journalists. 'We should have closed out that Pakistan game. We know that. It is simple to say but we choked that game. That is a fact. We have to go back and become a better team. There are no excuses.'

The public acknowledgement of failure was not much fun for me, just as it had not been much fun for Graeme Smith, and Shaun Pollock before him, and Hansie Cronjé before him. It will never be much fun until a Proteas team finally goes out and wins one of these ICC limited-overs tournaments. That will happen one day.

For us, in 2012, as ever, there was another series and another challenge around the corner.

Next stop ... a three-Test tour of Australia.

Towards the end of what had been a long year on the road, when we had won in New Zealand and in England and risen to No. 1 in the rankings, we approached the first Test in Brisbane with confidence and our excellent form continued as centuries by Hashim and Jacques helped us to a first-innings total of 450.

The team was looking so settled and strong – Smith and Petersen, Amla, Kallis, De Villiers, Duminy and Rudolph, Philander, Steyn, Kleinveldt and Morkel – and, even after the second day was lost to rain, we maintained the pressure and had the Australians reeling at 40 for three. If Ed Cowan had been dismissed cheaply – instead of escaping because Morné was judged to have bowled a no ball – we might have